

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ
دار الإفتاء النور

جمعية إشاعة أهل السنة
(باكستان)

THE SHARĪ'AH RULING ON VEGETARIANISM AND VEGANISM

The Question (al-Istiftā’):

A **vegetarian** is a person who does not eat meat, chicken or fish, but does consume milk and eggs.

A **vegan** is one who gives up milk, eggs, honey and all other animal-derived foods along with meat.

1. Is it permissible for a Muslim to do this?
2. If someone gives up meat out of pity for animals, or for reasons of health or the environment, what is the ruling?
3. Is giving up meat permanently contrary to the Sunnah or makrūh?
4. And if a person considers the very act of slaughtering an animal for food to be wrong, what is the ruling on this view of his?
5. Also, some people nowadays say that Sayyidunā ‘Umar (raḍiyallāhu ‘anhu) forbade meat; that there was little meat on the dining cloth of the Holy Prophet ﷺ, so his normal practice was to abstain from it; and that the Qur’ān has called animals "communities like you." What is the truth about these claims?

Bayyinū tu’jarū: kindly explain, and may you be rewarded.

(Questioner: Muhammad ‘Umar Fārūq, Boston, USA)

باسمہ تعالیٰ وتقّدر الجواب

In answering these questions, one point must first be understood. According to Islam – the religion of *fiṭra* (natural disposition), ḥalāl meat, milk, eggs and honey are all **mubāḥ** (permissible) foods and wholesome blessings.

To abstain from all or some of them, (i.e. not to eat them), is one thing; but to consider them ḥarām is quite another.

From this basic point and distinction, **four broad cases** arise:

First Case (*When Abstaining from Meat Becomes Farḍ i.e. Obligatory*)

A **Muslim in a non-Muslim country** who is **certain** that the **meat on sale is not ḥalāl** (lawful) must refrain from it.

This includes meat from **animals slaughtered by machine**, not slaughtered by proper dhabḥ (Islamic slaughter), or slaughtered by someone whose dhabīḥa (slaughtered animal) is not lawful. **Such meat is maytah (carrion) and ḥarām (forbidden)**, so **avoiding it is farḍ** (obligatory), not a personal choice.

Properly slaughtered ḥalāl meat stays lawful, including packed meat from a verified Muslim company whose genuine packaging can be recognised.

Second case: (*not a sin*)

A person who does not eat meat or other animal foods **because of his own temperament, taste, health, a doctor's advice, financial hardship or concern for the environment**, while at heart he regards them as ḥalāl, commits no sin. **Because if Allah has made something ḥalāl, that does not require every person to eat it necessarily.**

Third case: (*contrary to the Sunnah and prohibited*)

A person who gives up meat permanently, regarding its abandonment as part of religion, worship, *zuhd* (asceticism) or piety, is acting contrary to the Sunnah, and this is prohibited in the Sharīʿah. It is the very *rahbāniyyah* (monasticism) that the Holy Prophet ﷺ plainly forbade.

Fourth case: (*may lead to kufr*)

A person who **considers meat or animal foods to be ḥarām in the Sharīʿah, or declares the very slaughter of an animal for food to be “cruelty and a crime”**, actually holds a view that is outright **wrong and ḥarām**.

Since the permissibility of ḥalāl slaughtered animals (*dhabīḥah*), the obligation of *Qurbānī* (sacrifice) on Eid-ul-Aḍḥā in its prescribed circumstances, and the practice of sacrifice among the noble Prophets are established by definitive (*qaṭʿī*) evidence from the Qurʾān and Sunnah, **knowingly rejecting such a definitive ruling may constitute kufr**. In such a case, the person must repent and renew

his faith (*tajdīd al-īmān*), and if he is married, he must also renew his marriage (*tajdīd al-nikāḥ*).

However, **this ruling is not to be applied to any particular individual without knowing his exact words and intention.**

A person who, on seeing slaughter, merely feels a natural fear or distress, and does not consider it impermissible, falls under the second case, not the fourth one.

Other categories:

One major reason that has come to light for young people becoming vegan or vegetarian is their **opposition to factory farming**, and to **animals being raised and slaughtered with cruelty**.

On this, **the position of Islam is clear: keeping animals in cramped places, causing them unnecessary suffering during transport, leaving them hungry or thirsty, or causing needless pain during slaughter are prohibited practices.** Certain unnecessary practices in slaughter are specifically considered *makrūh*, as explained in the reference to *al-Hidāyah* below. **These wrong practices do not, however, make the meat of an otherwise lawful animal ḥarām.**

Environmental concerns also call for responsible use of resources. **The Sharī'ah forbids *isrāf* (extravagance and waste) and teaches moderation in the use and consumption of the blessings and resources of this world.**

Therefore, **the Islamic solution is to correct these wrong practices: to observe *iḥsān* (kindness and excellence) in slaughter, avoid waste and harm, and practise moderation in eating.** The solution is **not to abandon meat altogether or declare its consumption inherently cruel or unethical.**

References and Citations (*for scholars and students of knowledge*)

Allah ﷻ سبحانه وتعالى says in the Qur'ān:

﴿يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا لَا تَحْرِمُوا طَيِّبَاتِ مَا أَحَلَّ اللَّهُ لَكُمْ وَلَا تَعْتَدُوا إِنَّ اللَّهَ لَا يُحِبُّ الْمُعْتَدِينَ﴾
(المائدة: ٥/٨٧)

Translation: "O you who believe! Do not declare unlawful the pure things that Allah has made lawful for you, and do not exceed the limits. Indeed, those who exceed the limits are disliked by Allah." (*Kanz al-Īmān*)

Regarding the occasion of revelation (*shān-e nuzūl*) of the verse above, ‘Allāma Aḥmad ibn ‘Alī Abū Bakr **al-Jaṣṣāṣ al-Rāzī al-Ḥanafī** (raḥimahullāh, d. 370 AH) writes:

"وَرَوَى سَعِيدٌ عَنْ قَتَادَةَ قَالَ: كَانَ نَاسٌ مِنْ أَصْحَابِ رَسُولِ اللَّهِ ﷺ هُمُوا يَتْرَكُ اللَّحْمَ وَالنِّسَاءَ وَالْإِخْتِصَاءَ، فَأَنْزَلَ اللَّهُ: ﴿يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا لَا تَحْرِمُوا طَيِّبَاتِ مَا أَحَلَّ اللَّهُ لَكُمْ﴾ الْآيَةُ، فَبَلَغَ ذَلِكَ النَّبِيَّ ﷺ فَقَالَ: لَيْسَ فِي دِينِي تَرْكُ النِّسَاءِ وَلَا اللَّحْمِ وَلَا اتِّخَاذُ الصَّوَامِ."

(*Aḥkām al-Qur’ān* by al-Jaṣṣāṣ, al-‘Ilmiyya edition, vol. 2, Sūrat al-Mā’ida, 2/565. Dār al-Kutub al-‘Ilmiyya, Beirut, Lebanon, 1st ed., 1415 AH / 1994 CE)

Translation:

Ḥaḍrat Qatāda (raḥimahullāh) says that some Companions of the Messenger of Allah ﷺ resolved to give up meat and women and to castrate themselves. So Allah (سبحانه و تعالى) revealed this verse: (O you who believe! Do not declare unlawful the pure things Allah has made lawful for you). When this reached the **Holy Prophet** ﷺ, he said:

"In my religion there is no giving up of women, nor of meat, nor retreating into places of worship like monks."

Imām Abu al-Ḥusayn **Muslim** ibn al-Ḥajjāj al-Qushayrī al-Naysābūrī (raḥimahullāh, d. 261 AH) narrates, with his chain of transmission, from **Sayyidunā Anas ibn Mālīk** (raḍiyallāhu ‘anhu):

"أَنَّ نَفَرًا مِنْ أَصْحَابِ النَّبِيِّ ﷺ سَأَلُوا أَزْوَاجَ النَّبِيِّ ﷺ عَنْ عَمَلِهِ فِي السِّرِّ، فَقَالَ بَعْضُهُمْ: لَا أَتَزَوَّجُ النِّسَاءَ، وَقَالَ بَعْضُهُمْ: لَا أَكُلُ اللَّحْمَ، وَقَالَ بَعْضُهُمْ: لَا أَنَامُ عَلَى فِرَاشٍ. فَحَمَدَ اللَّهُ وَأَثْنَى عَلَيْهِ فَقَالَ: مَا بَالُ أَقْوَامٍ قَالُوا كَذَا وَكَذَا؟ لَكِنِّي أَصْلِي وَأَنَامُ، وَأَصُومُ وَأُفْطِرُ، وَأَتَزَوَّجُ النِّسَاءَ، فَمَنْ رَغِبَ عَنْ سُنَّتِي فَلَيْسَ مِنِّي."

(*Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim*, ed. ‘Abd al-Bāqī, Kitāb al-Nikāḥ, Bāb Istiḥbāb al-Nikāḥ li-man Tāqat Nafsuhi ilayhi wa Wajada Mu’natahu, wa Ishtighāl man ‘Ajaza ‘an al-Mu’an bi-l-Ṣawm, ḥadīth no. 1401, 2/1020. Maṭba‘at ‘Isā al-Bābī al-Ḥalabī wa Shurakāh, Cairo, 1374 AH / 1955 CE)

Translation:

"A few Companions asked the wives of the Holy Prophet ﷺ about the Holy Prophet's ﷺ practice when alone. (On hearing it,) one of them said, 'I will not

marry.' Another said, 'I will not eat meat.' Another said, 'I will not sleep on a bed.' The Prophet ﷺ praised and glorified Allah, then said: 'What is the matter with people who say such-and-such? As for me, I pray and I also sleep; I fast and I also break my fast; and I also marry. So whoever turns away from my Sunnah is not of me.'"

This ḥadīth shows that those **Companions wished to give up ḥalāl things in order to withdraw from the world** and devote more time to worship, not because they thought these things impermissible or cruel. **Even so, they were forbidden from doing it.**

According to the commentators on ḥadīth,

"Sunnah" in this ḥadīth means the way of the Holy Prophet ﷺ, not the technical term Sunnah as opposed to *fard*. Turning away from the Sunnah means that a person deliberately abandons it and does not accept it as the way of the Prophet ﷺ.

At this point the scholars have also made clear that true virtue lies in following the Prophet ﷺ, not in deeming some particular manner or form of worship superior by one's own opinion.

(*Fath al-Bārī bi-Sharḥ al-Bukhārī*, Kitāb al-Nikāḥ, Bāb al-Targhīb fi al-Nikāḥ, 9/105–106. al-Maktaba al-Salafiyya, Egypt, 1st ed., 1380–1390 AH),

(*Riyāḍ al-Ṣāliḥīn*, Bāb fi al-Iqtiṣād fi al-ʿIbāda, p. 66. Dār Ibn Kathīr, Damascus and Beirut, 1st ed., 1428 AH / 2007 CE),

(*Fath al-Qadīr* by al-Kamāl ibn al-Humām, Kitāb al-Nikāḥ, 3/188. Sharikat Maktabat wa Maṭbaʿat Muṣṭafā al-Bābī al-Ḥalabī wa Awlādiḥ, Egypt, 1st ed., 1389 AH / 1970 CE)

Therefore, a person who does not eat some ḥalāl thing merely out of temperament or for some worldly reason does not come under this warning. Otherwise, everyone who happens to dislike some ḥalāl food would be included in it, and that is plainly not correct.

Now citing the **Holy Prophet's** ﷺ **own practice**

Imām Abū ʿĪsā Muḥammad ibn ʿĪsā **al-Tirmidhī** (raḥimahullāh, d. 279 AH) narrates, with his chain of transmission, from **Sayyidunā Abū Hurayra** (raḍiyallāhu ʿanhu):

"أَتَى النَّبِيَّ ﷺ بِلَحْمٍ فَرَفَعَ إِلَيْهِ الذَّرَاعُ، وَكَانَتْ تُعْجِبُهُ، فَهَسَ مِنْهَا."

(*al-Shamā'il al-Muḥammadiyya* by al-Tirmidhī, Bāb mā Jā'a fī Ṣifāt Idām Rasūl Allāh ﷺ, ḥadīth no. 168, p. 140. al-Maktaba al-Tijāriyya, Muṣṭafā Aḥmad al-Bāz, Makkah al-Mukarrama, 1st ed., 1413 AH / 1993 CE)

Translation:

Meat was brought to the Holy Prophet ﷺ and the foreleg was handed up to him. He liked the foreleg, so he ate from it.

In case a person declares some ḥalāl thing unlawful for himself alone

‘Allāma Aḥmad ibn ‘Alī Abū Bakr al-Jaṣṣāṣ al-Rāzī al-Ḥanafī (raḥimahullāh, d. 370 AH) writes at the same place:

«وَفَرَّقَ أَصْحَابُنَا بَيْنَ مَنْ قَالَ: «وَاللَّهِ لَا أَكُلُ هَذَا الطَّعَامَ» وَبَيْنَ قَوْلِهِ: «حَرَّمْتُهُ عَلَى نَفْسِي»، فَقَالُوا فِي التَّحْرِيمِ: إِنْ أَكَلَ الْجُزْءَ مِنْهُ حَنْثٌ، وَفِي الْإِيمَانِ لَا يَحْنُثُ إِلَّا بِأَكْلِ الْجَمِيعِ.»

(*Aḥkām al-Qur'ān* by al-Jaṣṣāṣ, Sūrat al-Mā'ida, 2/565. Dār al-Kutub al-'Ilmiyya, Beirut, Lebanon, 1st ed., 1415 AH / 1994 CE)

Translation:

"Our Ḥanafī scholars have distinguished between the person who says, 'By Allah, I will not eat this food,' and the person who says, 'I have made it unlawful for myself.' They said: where he has declared it unlawful, his oath is broken if he eats even a little of it; whereas with an explicit oath, it is not broken until he eats all of it."

Therefore, **if someone has said, "I have made meat unlawful for myself," meat has not become ḥarām for him. Rather, this takes the ruling of an oath.** He should eat what is ḥalāl and pay the expiation (kaffāra) for the oath, and he should not go on believing it to be ḥarām for him.

The Ruling on Regarding the ḥalāl as ḥarām

‘Allāma Zayn al-Dīn ibn Ibrāhīm, known as **Ibn Nujaym al-Miṣrī al-Ḥanafī** (raḥimahullāh, d. 970 AH), writes:

«وَالْأَصْلُ أَنَّ مَنْ اعْتَقَدَ الْحَرَامَ حَلَالًا، فَإِنْ كَانَ حَرَامًا لِغَيْرِهِ كَمَالِ الْغَيْرِ لَا يَكْفُرُ، وَإِنْ كَانَ لِعَيْنِهِ فَإِنْ كَانَ دَلِيلُهُ قَطْعِيًّا كَفَرَ، وَإِلَّا فَلَا.»

(*al-Baḥr al-Rā'iq Sharḥ Kanz al-Daqa'iq*, Kitāb al-Siyar, Bāb Aḥkām al-Murtaddīn, 5/132. Dār al-Kitāb al-Islāmī, 2nd ed.)

Translation:

"The principle is that when someone believes a ḥarām thing to be ḥalāl: if the thing was ḥarām because of something else (*li-ghayrihi*), not in itself, such as another person's property, he does not become a *kāfir*. If it was ḥarām in itself (*li-ʿaynihi*), then it will be examined: if its prohibition is established by a definitive proof, he becomes a *kāfir*; otherwise not."

The reason for this ruling is that, in a matter of ḥalāl and ḥarām, such a person is rejecting a definitive proof. To call something which is definitively ḥarām, ḥalāl - is *kufur*.

Similarly, to regard the consumption of meat as cruelty or a crime, despite their permissibility being established by definitive proof and their consumption being part of the Sunnah of the Prophets, constitutes a rejection of that established proof and is contrary to faith.

Regarding Mercy to Animals and Needless Pain in Slaughter

ʿAllāma Burhān al-Dīn Abu al-Ḥasan ʿAlī ibn Abī Bakr al-Marghīnānī al-Ḥanafī (rahimahullāh, d. 593 AH) writes:

"وَهَذَا لِأَنَّ فِي جَمِيعِ ذَلِكَ وَفِي قَطْعِ الرَّأْسِ زِيَادَةً تَعْذِيبُ الْحَيَوَانَ بِلَا فَائِدَةٍ، وَهُوَ مَنْهِيٌّ عَنْهُ. وَالْحَاصِلُ: أَنَّ مَا فِيهِ زِيَادَةٌ إِيْلَامٍ لَا يَحْتَاجُ إِلَيْهِ فِي الزَّكَاةِ، مَكْرُوهٌ. وَيَكْرَهُ أَنْ يَجْرَ مَا يُرِيدُ ذَبْحَهُ بِرِجْلِهِ إِلَى الْمَذْبَحِ، وَأَنْ تُنْخَعِ الشَّاةُ قَبْلَ أَنْ تَبْرُدَ: يَعْنِي تَسْكُنَ مِنَ الْاضْطِرَابِ، وَبَعْدَهُ لَا أَلَمَ فَلَا يَكْرَهُ النَّخْعُ وَالسَّلْخُ، إِلَّا أَنَّ الْكَرَاهَةَ لِمَعْنَى زَائِدٍ وَهُوَ زِيَادَةُ الْأَلَمِ قَبْلَ الذَّبْحِ، أَوْ بَعْدَهُ، فَلَا يُوجِبُ التَّحْرِيمَ، فَلِهَذَا قَالَ: تَوَكَّلْ ذَيْبِحَتَهُ."

(*al-Hidāya fī Sharḥ Bidāyat al-Mubtadī*, Kitāb al-Dhabāʿih, Man Taḥillu Dhabīḥatuhu wa man lā Taḥill, 4/350. Dār Iḥyāʾ al-Turāth al-ʿArabī, Beirut, Lebanon, 1st ed., 1425 AH / 2004 CE)

Translation:

"In all these cases, and in cutting off the head, there is needless additional suffering for the animal, and this has been forbidden. In short, any additional pain in slaughter that is not needed is makrūh.

It is also makrūh to drag the animal one means to slaughter to the place of slaughter by its leg, or to cut through the goat's neck (*nakhʿ*) before it has stopped writhing. Once it has become still, there is no pain, so cutting the neck and skinning are then not makrūh. This dislike is due to an additional factor, namely the extra pain before or after slaughter, and so it does not entail prohibition. That

is why he said: an animal slaughtered (in such a manner can) be eaten (it being primarily ḥalāl)."

This passage settles both points.

First: **causing an animal pain without reason is forbidden** and makrūh in the Sharīʿah.

Second: Imām al-Marghīnānī (the author of al-Hidāya) himself states plainly that this dislike does not make the slaughtered animal ḥarām. In other words, **the command to show mercy to animals refines the manner of slaughter, it does not cancel the ruling of slaughter or its lawfulness.**

Qurbānī Is Not Waived for a Vegetarian or Vegan

The conditions for *qurbānī* i.e. the prescribed sacrifice offered on Eid-ul-Aḍḥā to be *wājib* (obligatory) are:

(i) being a Muslim, (ii) being a resident (*muqīm*), and (iii) possessing the required *niṣāb* (the minimum level of wealth that makes *qurbānī* obligatory).

(*Radd al-Muḥtār ‘alā al-Durr al-Mukhtār*, Kitāb al-Uḍḥiya, under his words: وَشَرَّائِطُهَا, 6/312. Sharikat Maktabat wa Maṭba‘at Muṣṭafā al-Bābī al-Ḥalabī wa Awlādih, Egypt, 2nd ed., 1386 AH / 1966 CE)

Eating the meat is neither a condition of *qurbānī* nor necessary for its validity. The essential act of *qurbānī* is the prescribed sacrifice of the animal for the sake of Allah. The distribution and consumption of its meat are among its related purposes and benefits.

Therefore, a Muslim who is vegetarian or vegan for lawful reasons, as explained in the first case above, is not exempt from *qurbānī*. He need not eat the meat himself; he may give it to relatives and the poor.

Clearing Up Misconceptions (Izālatush Shubuhāt)

First misconception: "Sayyidunā ‘Umar (raḍiyallāhu ‘anhu) forbade meat"

This *athar* (report) does exist, but it has a context.

Imām Mālik ibn Anas (raḥimahullāh, d. 179 AH) narrates, with his chain of transmission, from **Sayyidunā ‘Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb** (raḍiyallāhu ‘anhu):

"إِيَّاكُمْ وَاللَّحْمَ، فَإِنَّ لَهُ ضَرَاوَةً كَضَرَاوَةِ الْخَمْرِ."

(*Muwatta’ Mālik*, *riwāyat Yahyā*, ed. ‘Abd al-Bāqī, Kitāb Ṣifat al-Nabī ﷺ, Bāb mā Jā’a fī Akl al-Laḥm, ḥadīth no. 36, 2/935. Dār Iḥyā’ al-Turāth al-‘Arabī, Beirut, Lebanon, 1406

Translation: "Beware of (too much) meat, for it becomes a craving, like the craving for wine."

Using this as an argument for vegetarianism is incorrect, for four reasons:

1. *Ḍarāwa* means a craving and becoming habituated. The statement restrains from excess and indulgence, not from meat itself. And to restrain someone from excess in a thing is itself an admission that the thing is permissible; with something ḥarām, there is no question of more or less at all.
2. ‘Allāmah Abū al-Walīd al-Bājī al-Mālikī (d. 474 AH) explains this narration in the same way. Sayyidunā ‘Umar’s warning was **not a general ban on meat**. Rather, he was discouraging people from eating too much meat, making it a constant habit, and becoming too attached to a life of comfort and luxury. (*al-Muntaqā Sharḥ al-Muwaṭṭa’*, Kitāb al-Jāmi’, mā Jā’a fī Akl al-Laḥm, 7/253, Maṭba‘at al-Sa‘āda, 1st ed., 1332 AH)
3. In the report that comes directly after it in Imām Mālik’s *Muwaṭṭa’*, Sayyidunā ‘Umar (raḍiyallāhu ‘anhu) saw Sayyidunā Jābir (raḍiyallāhu ‘anhu) carrying meat he had just bought. He did not tell him that eating it was wrong; he reminded him that **while there is nothing wrong with satisfying one’s own desire, a person should also be mindful of his neighbour and any needy relatives**. (ibid., under ḥadīth no. 36, 2/936)
Imām al-Bājī al-Mālikī also mentions that Sayyidunā ‘Umar’s advice may have been **an administrative measure taken during a time of famine and hardship**. Measures of this kind are based on circumstances and are therefore temporary; they can change when circumstances change. (*Al-Muntaqā Sharḥ al-Muwaṭṭa’*, Kitāb al-Jāmi’, Mā Jā’a fī Akl al-Laḥm, 7/253, Maṭba‘at al-Sa‘ādah, 1st ed., 1332 AH.)
4. There is also an issue with the chain of this report. In the *Muwaṭṭa’*, it is narrated by Yaḥyā ibn Sa‘īd from Sayyidunā ‘Umar (raḍiyallāhu ‘anhu), although Yaḥyā ibn Sa‘īd did not meet him. The chain is therefore **disconnected (munqaṭi’)**. Some later attempts were also made to trace the report back to the Prophet ﷺ, but the scholars of ḥadīth did not accept that attribution.

So, in its proper context, **this report is a reminder to avoid excess and maintain moderation. It should not be used as the basis for a permanent**

legal ruling. (*Shu‘ab al-Īmān*, *al-Faṣl al-Thānī fī Dhamm Kathrat al-Akl*, ḥadīth no. 5284, 7/461; *al-Tamhīd* by Ibn ‘Abd al-Barr, 2/464.)

Second misconception: "Eating meat was not the Holy Prophet's ﷺ habit"

The fact that no fire was lit in the household of the Holy Prophet ﷺ for months at a time reflects **zuhd (detachment from worldly comforts)**, not any particular view about, or prohibition of, a specific type of food. On the contrary, there are clear reports that the Prophet ﷺ ate meat. As mentioned earlier in the ḥadīth of *al-Shamā’il*, he ﷺ liked the foreleg. Something that he ﷺ liked when it was available cannot be described as something he had abandoned.

Moreover, *hady* (the sacrificial animal offered during Ḥajj), *qurbānī* (the sacrifice offered on Eid-ul-Adḥā), *walīmah* (the wedding feast), and *‘aqīqah* (the sacrifice offered on the occasion of a child's birth) all provide further evidence that lawful meat was not something the Prophet ﷺ prohibited or regarded as inherently undesirable.

Third misconception: "The Qur’ān has called animals communities like you, so we should not eat them"

The context of verse 38 of Sūrat al-An‘ām is creation and resurrection: these too are creatures of Allah and will be gathered back to their Lord.

To conclude from this that animals and humans are equal in rights goes against the context. The very Book that contains this verse also contains the lawfulness of eating meat of ḥalāl livestock and the rulings on *hady* and *qurbānī*.

One verse of the Qur’ān should not be interpreted in a manner that conflicts with clear and definitive rulings established elsewhere in the same Qur’ān. This is not the approach of the people of knowledge.

Fourth Misconception: "Fatwas from scholars in Western and developed Muslim-minority countries allow Muslims to abstain from meat"

PETA (People for the Ethical Treatment of Animals), an animal-rights organisation, has cited a number of fatwas in support of vegetarianism among Muslims. However, when we read these fatwas in full, including their conditions and explanations the claim is misleading.

Some of the fatwas clearly state that **giving up meat should not be considered better, more rewarding, or a means of drawing closer to Allah.**

Some even compare such an attitude to the practice of Brahmins and monks.

Others state that a **Muslim may choose to be vegetarian, provided he does not consider meat ḥarām or believe that avoiding it is a religious virtue.**

Thus, **these fatwas allow a person to avoid meat as a personal choice; they do not establish that avoiding meat is religiously better or more virtuous.**

Quoting only the word “permissible” while leaving out the conditions attached to it can give an incomplete picture of the actual ruling.

A ruling should therefore be understood in its full context. It is not sound to select statements from different scholars simply because they appear to support a preferred view, while leaving aside the conditions and explanations given by those scholars.

Fifth Misconception: “Modern conditions, environmental concerns, and industrial slaughterhouses require responsible Muslims to avoid meat and animal products”

These concerns are important, but they are separate from the ruling on meat, milk, and eggs themselves.

Modern problems should be addressed by correcting the wrong practices themselves, not by changing the ruling on something that the Sharīʿah has permitted.

The Sharīʿah commands kindness towards animals. Keeping animals in cramped conditions, causing them unnecessary suffering during transport, leaving them hungry or thirsty, or causing needless pain during slaughter are already prohibited. Certain unnecessary practices in slaughter are specifically considered *makrūh*, as explained in the reference to *al-Hidāyah*.

Environmental concerns also call for responsible use of resources. **The Sharīʿah forbids *isrāf* (extravagance and waste) and teaches moderation in the use and consumption of the blessings and resources of this world.** This means that wasteful or harmful practices should be reduced and resources should be used responsibly. However, these principles do not by themselves change the

ruling of a food that Allah has made lawful. A concern about how something is produced, transported, or consumed must be addressed at the level of those practices; it does not make the lawful thing itself unlawful.

Therefore, the **Islamic solution is to correct these wrong practices: to observe *iḥsān* (kindness and excellence) in slaughter, avoid waste and harm, and practise moderation in eating.** The solution is **not to abandon meat altogether or declare its consumption inherently cruel or unethical.**

A wrong practice connected to something permissible does not make the permissible thing itself unlawful. For example, wrong customs at weddings do not make *nikāḥ* forbidden, and un-Islamic practices associated with shrines do not make visiting the graves of the righteous impermissible. Likewise, mistreatment of animals does not make meat, eggs, or other lawful animal products impermissible.

Summary of the Ruling

1. **Giving up meat and animal foods because of personal preference, health, illness, financial hardship, or environmental concerns is *mubāḥ* (permissible).** Such a person is **not sinful**, and simply avoiding these foods does not make the action *makrūḥ* or contrary to the Sunnah.
2. **Giving up meat and animal foods permanently while believing that this is an act of worship, *zuhd* (voluntary detachment from worldly comforts), or a way of gaining greater religious merit, falls under the meaning of *rahbāniyyah* (monasticism and religious renunciation).** Such an attitude is contrary to the Sunnah, and it is prohibited in the Sharīʿah.
3. **Believing meat, milk, eggs, or honey to be ḥarām when their permissibility is established by clear and definitive Islamic evidence is itself ḥarām and leads to *kufr*.** If a person knowingly rejects a definitive ruling of Islam and declares something that Allah has made lawful to be ḥarām, this may constitute *kufr*. In such a case, repentance and renewal of faith are required, and if the person is married, renewal of *nikāḥ* is also required. However, this ruling cannot be applied to a particular person without first knowing his exact words, what he meant by them, and the circumstances in which they were said.

4. **Preventing others from eating ḥalāl meat, or calling them sinful or unethical merely because they eat it, is impermissible.**
5. **For a resident Muslim who possesses the required *niṣāb* (the minimum level of wealth that makes *qurbānī* obligatory), offering a prescribed sacrificial animal as *qurbānī* on Eid-ul-Aḍḥā is *wājib* (obligatory).** This remains the case even if he does not eat meat. He may simply give the meat to relatives and the poor. What he cannot do is leave *qurbānī* itself.
6. **Causing an animal unnecessary pain, including needless suffering during slaughter, is prohibited, and certain unnecessary practices in slaughter are *makrūh*.** However, such wrongdoing does not by itself make the meat of an otherwise lawful animal ḥarām.
7. **Excessive consumption of meat, or of food in general, and becoming overly accustomed to it are discouraged.** Islam requires moderation. However, the command to be moderate is not evidence that meat should be abandoned altogether.

وَاللَّهُ تَعَالَىٰ أَعْلَمُ بِالصَّوَابِ

And Allah تَعَالَىٰ سبحانه knows best what is right.

16 Rabīʿ al-Thānī 1448 AH / 28 September 2026 CE

M. Tahir



Abu al-Layth **Muḥammad Ṭāhir al-Qādirī** al-Naʿīmī

ENDORSEMENTS:

Al-Jawābu Ṣaḥīḥun wal-Mujību Najīḥ

(The answer is correct, and the respondent is sound in his judgment.)

عبد الله بن محمد

Dr. Muftī Muḥammad ‘Aṭā’ullāh an-Naʿīmī

Shaykh al-Ḥadīth, Jāmiʿat an-Nūr and Madrasah Anwār al-Qurʾān
Head, Dārul Iftā an-Nūr, Jamiyyat Ishaat Ahl-e-Sunnat (Pakistan), Karachi

Al-Jawābu Ṣaḥīḥ
(The answer is correct.)



Muftī Muḥammad Junaid al-‘Aṭṭārī an-Na‘īmī
Dārul Iftā, Jamiyyat Ishaat Ahl-e-Sunnat (Pakistan), Karachi

Al-Jawābu Ṣaḥīḥ
(The answer is correct.)

Muftī Muḥammad Shahzād al-‘Aṭṭārī an-Na‘īmī
Dārul Iftā, Jamiyyat Ishaat Ahl-e-Sunnat (Pakistan), Karachi

Muftī ‘Abdur Raḥmān Qādirī
Dārul Iftā Gharīb Nawāz, Limbe Jāmi‘ Masjid, Malawi, Central Africa

Abū Thawbān Muftī Muḥammad Kāshif al-‘Aṭṭārī an-Na‘īmī
Dārul Iftā, Jamiyyat Ishaat Ahl-e-Sunnat (Pakistan), Karachi

Abū Ḥamzah Muftī Muḥammad Ṭāriq al-‘Aṭṭārī an-Na‘īmī
Dārul Iftā, Jamiyyat Ishaat Ahl-e-Sunnat (Pakistan), Karachi

Abū ‘Āṭif Muftī Muḥammad Āṣif Ḥanīf al-‘Aṭṭārī an-Na‘īmī
Dārul Iftā, Jamiyyat Ishaat Ahl-e-Sunnat (Pakistan), Karachi